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Terminological equivalence thus reflects extrahousehold role equivalence, and outside the household the kinship system facilitates substitution of any one individual in a category by another in the same category. This ease of substitution outside the boundaries of the household reflects the independence and solidarity of the domestic group itself. From this independence, and from the facility of substitution among persons included in the extrahousehold kin network, stems the ease with which the processes of fusion and fission can occur, both within the band and between bands. The combination of low fission inertia (i.e., low resistance to processes of separation) and high fusion valency (i.e., a readiness to join together) are features of major importance in the socioecosystem of the G/wi.

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Kinship and marriage

A G/wi girl is married when aged between 7 and 9 years to a boy some 7 years older. My informants stated that the preferred marriage is one between cross-cousins, between a boy and the daughter of either his real or classificatory mother's brother or father's sister. The couple should live attached to the household of the wife's parents until their first, or even second, child is born, after which they are regarded as an autonomous household and should go to live among the husband's people. The view of informants was that brother and sister would not normally spend their adult lives in the same band, which, together with the preference for cross-cousin marriages, implies a strain toward band exogamy.

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As I have already mentioned, actual behavior does not always accord with what people told me ought to be done. My analysis of existing marriages and band members' speculation about the future spouses of single boys and girls revealed a marked discrepancy between the evident vernacular ideal of cross-cousin, virilocal, band-exogamous marriages and actual practice. Of the 73 marriages adequately analyzed during the survey, only three were between men and the daughters of their father's sister and five married daughters of their mother's brother, that is, only 11 percent were cross-cousin marriages. My attempts to elicit explanations of the divergence between preference and practice were fruitless, and it became clear that I was asking questions based on my literal interpretation of the stated preferences and that these questions were meaningless to the informants. What did emerge was that all first marriages (as distinct from subsequent marriages of widowed or divorced persons) had been between boys and girls in a *n//odima-n//odisa* relationship, which is the  150 terminological equivalent of cross-cousinship and, hence, placed the two in a joking relationship. It was not possible to obtain details of the relationship that had existed between the respective parents of couples before the latter had married. However, the speculation about the future marriages of boys and girls did throw a good deal of light on this matter. Approval of a suitor is much readier if he and his parents are well known to, and on friendly terms with, the girl's parents. Answers to further questions and my own observations confirmed this indication. This suggested another interpretation of the marriage "rule," namely, that the kinship model of cross-cousinship was being used to express the ideal prerequisites of marriage. The kinship model contains three elements: First, the boy and girl should be joking partners and not in an avoidance relationship; second, the two sets of parents should be on friendly terms and know enough about each other's children to judge their mutual compatibility of temperament; and third, the parents should have the trust and affection of the couple and thus be able to guide them in times of marital stress. This last aspect is of particular relevance to the girl's parents during the years of initial uxorilocality, the period of residence with the wife's parents. An additional feature of the kinship model precludes intermarriage between the two sets of parents should death or divorce end their marriages and leave one of each set single and eligible for remarriage. From the point of view of the young couple, marriage between a parent and a parent-in-law would result in an intolerable rearrangement of the statuses of the spouses and their mutual kin.

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